

The good news? You also aren't limited to growing your income by only 3 to 5 percent each year. With effort and planning, it's possible to increase your income more than that. Even better, you do have some control over how much you can earn. But you won't make more magically. You need to manage your career. That process can be further subdivided, learning to manage yourself and manage your boss.

Manage Yourself

Working hard is great, but you also need to work smart. Most people work hard. This keeps you employed. If you're lucky, you'll get the 3 percent annual raise. If you're really lucky to be in a thriving company and industry, you may get 5 percent. But do you want to rely on luck?

There are things you can do to increase your value to others. This is the most reliable way to increase your income. ESI pointed out that most people will do what is expected of them, but only a few exceptional employees are proactive in looking to increase their value. If you're not sure what you can do to be more valuable to your employer, just ask them. ESI noted that, in his experience as the president of a company, these conversations were rare, and he